

Children, Youth and Media in 2026



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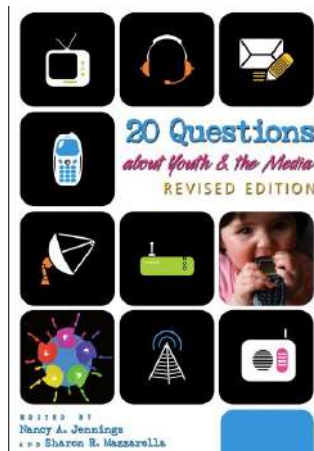
Creator.

Educator.

Researcher.



Professor, Media Studies & Production
Director, Certificate in Children's Media



Board, Global MIL Alliance
Chair in Media & Information Literacy

Goals

UNDERSTAND:

Deepen your understanding of cross-platform media influence on children and youth

OPINION:

Build personal opinions based on research and reflection

ACTION:

Determine where your actions can be most effective

Living a Mediated Life

Music:
Shazam,
Spotify,
SiriusXM,
YouTube

Shopping:
Amazon,
Quince Ebay,
Ulta, Target,
Poshmark

Family life:
Uber,
Fandango,
Nest, Zoom,
Starbucks

Streaming:
Hulu, Netflix,
Apple TV+,
Amazon Prime,
HBO, YouTube

Podcasts:
Armchair Expert
Las Culturistas
Smartless
Hard Fork
Today Explained

Social Media:
TikTok,
Facebook,
Instagram
Linked In
What's App

Reading:
Kindle,
NY Times,
New York mag

Work:
Researchgate
Google Drive
SHC.com
Kids Talk Media

Games:
Bitmoji, Heads
Up, Toca Hair
Salon

Travel:
Hotels.com,
Trivago,
Booking.com,
Trip Advisor



Thoughts? Concerns?

Internet
Memes
A.I.
Social media
Books
Podcasts
Movies
Television
Music
Apps
Radio
Streaming
Video games
Devices
Regulations
Bans
Cost
Time spent
Copyright
Movie franchises
Culture wars
Deep fakes
Disinformation
Fact checking
Passwords

Media has always been influential on children and youth.
But in today's media focused world, it is even more so.
Why?



Their **EASE** of
access to the
message



Their parasocial
RELATIONSHIP with
the person providing
the message.



The **SPEED** in which
they share the
message.

WHAT'S ON MY MIND

A FILM BY FLOOR ADAMS

My Top Ten

a CINÉTÉ FABRIQUE FANTASTIQUE CURIOUS WOLF PRODUCTION "MIND MY MIND" PRODUCED BY WILLEM THIJSSSEN, TOM VAN GESTEL, FLOOR ADAMS. ANIMATED BY NANCY BENS, JUAN DE GRAAF, CARL VAN ISACKER, ELIE KLIMIS, TIM TRENSON, PETER WASSINK. VOICES BY SAMIN RIDHOES, CELIANE TEBELBERG, ADAM FIELDS, IVE BLOOMFIELD, LESLEY HUGHES, ELIAS VERVECKEN. PRODUCTION DESIGN BY FLOOR ADAMS. EDITED BY DENNIS PASVEER, LOUK POELS. ORIGINAL MUSIC BY PETER JONAN NYLAND, FRANK UDELUIN. SOUND DESIGN BY PETER DEVELTJOT. STORY BY ELIAS VERVECKEN. WRITTEN AND DIRECTED BY FLOOR ADAMS.



Influence of Influencers



MrBeast: Jimmy Donaldson

Today's pop culture Influencers connect to children and youth directly and personally online everyday. They shape their thoughts about sports, movies, music, and money.

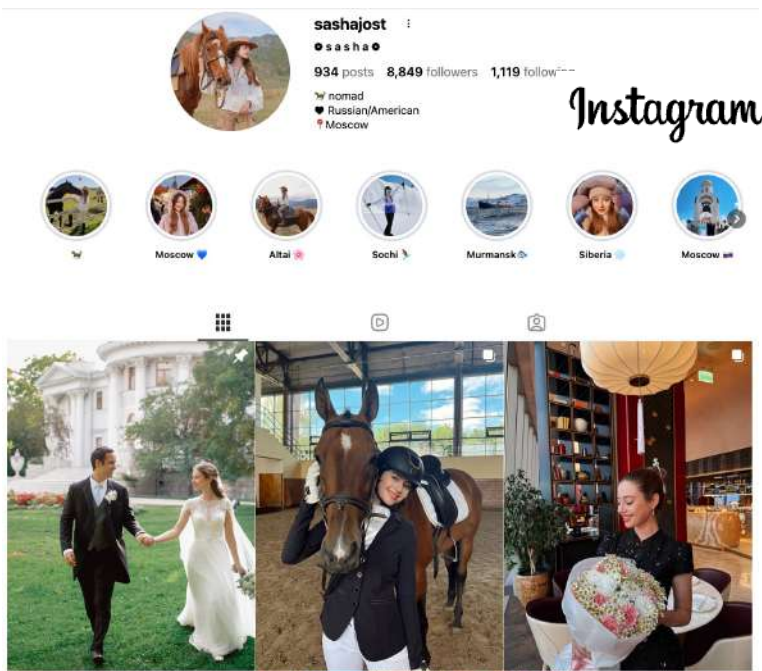


xQc: Félix Lengyel

Influencers also share **value messages**. They shape children's beliefs about what it means to be 'normal', what's worth fighting for, the meaning of a "good" job, etc.

Pop culture as propaganda

Not all messages are created by individual Influencers. Youth are increasingly subjected to pop culture messages created by powerful agents influencing their thoughts about education, public health, political beliefs and other societal issues.



"...she inserts pro-Russian propaganda and messaging, with the Council of the European Union stating that she "built an extensive base of followers under the guise of cultural coverage, while focusing on pro-war and pro-Kremlin propaganda with regard to Ukraine, and supporting the Kremlin's political establishment and the Russian armed forces."

europa
news.



Pop culture propaganda uses common entertainment structures or humor structures to engage youth and the messages have power and influence.

Zootopia 2 Teaches Kids They Have Trauma And It's Their Parents' Fault

BY: BROOKE BRANDTJEN

DECEMBER 10, 2025

🕒 5 MIN READ



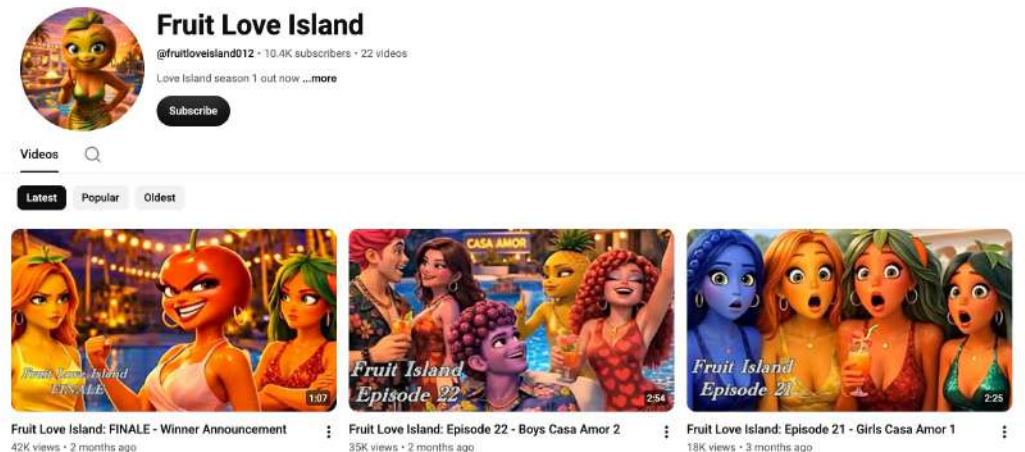
A.I. chatbots

Children are having fun talking to and playing with digital assistants and conversational agents. These bots are always available, always willing to listen. What effect is this having on children's ability to connect to real humans? to *want to* connect to real humans?



Inspiring creativity

Creating is an important component of life online. But real creating takes time, failure, and lots of revisions. If children and youth keep hearing stories about how A.I. bots can do everything faster and easier, why even try? How can children and youth continue to be inspired to explore their creativity?



Trust in news

“Don’t trust any source” – this is the message repeated to youth under the guise of fact-checking and verification. What are the consequences of raising youth to believe trust in journalism is impossible? How will democracy continue when it necessitates trust in a “fifth estate” of journalism?



Classroom battleground

Take smartphones out of schools! No, bring technology into the classroom! No, give students a space free from digital assault!

No, teach students media literacy!

How can educators bring media literacy into their classrooms if schools have restrictive rules about digital media? Do students need school to be a screen-free zone? Or should classrooms incorporate screens to prepare students for the real world? And who gets to decide?



Politicizing MIL

Youth need to be encouraged to question, analyze, and evaluate media. This is the cornerstone of MIL, and also of building civic minded youth. But more and more, the very act of analyzing media is being seen by some parents and politicians as a “woke” liberal agenda.



Social media age restrictions



“Social media age restrictions improve youth mental health.”

“Social media age restrictions help children build social skills so they will be better prepared to handle social media in their teens.”

Are these statements true?

Such moral panics have confronted every new technology.

Are age restrictions an action worth taking even if the proof they work is negligible?

Or do age restrictions create a false sense of protection for media literacy skills that are best scaffolded over time?

Tech accountability

Messages youth hear often about online safety;

“educators should teach media literacy skills”

“parents should be monitoring their child’s online use”

“parents can access the parental guidelines on the social media site”

“elected officials need to change the regulations”

What youth rarely hear?

Tech companies and media companies changing *their own* policies, *their own* algorithms, *their own* revenue-generating methods to proactively create an online space safe for all.



Ethical awareness



Should you share that private image? Should you use AI for that assignment? Should you catfish that unpopular student? Should you breakup with a one-line text? Should you share that funny disinformation meme?

Digital media issues facing children and youth are often ethical questions. Ethics is about questioning, not dictating morality. How might youth benefit if they understood the ethical choices inherent in their online actions?

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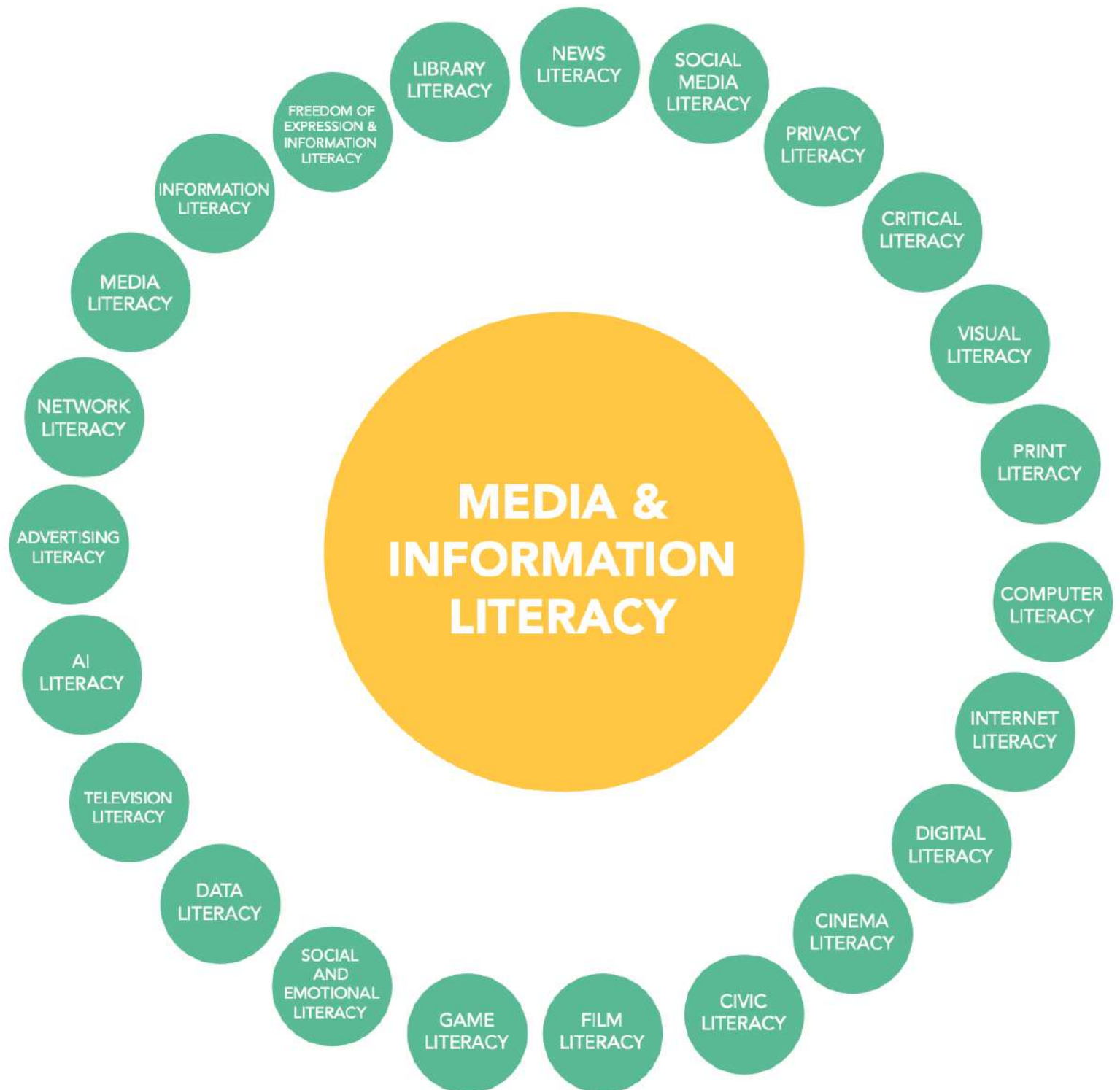


***The ability to
access, analyze,
evaluate, create
and act using
all forms of
communication.***

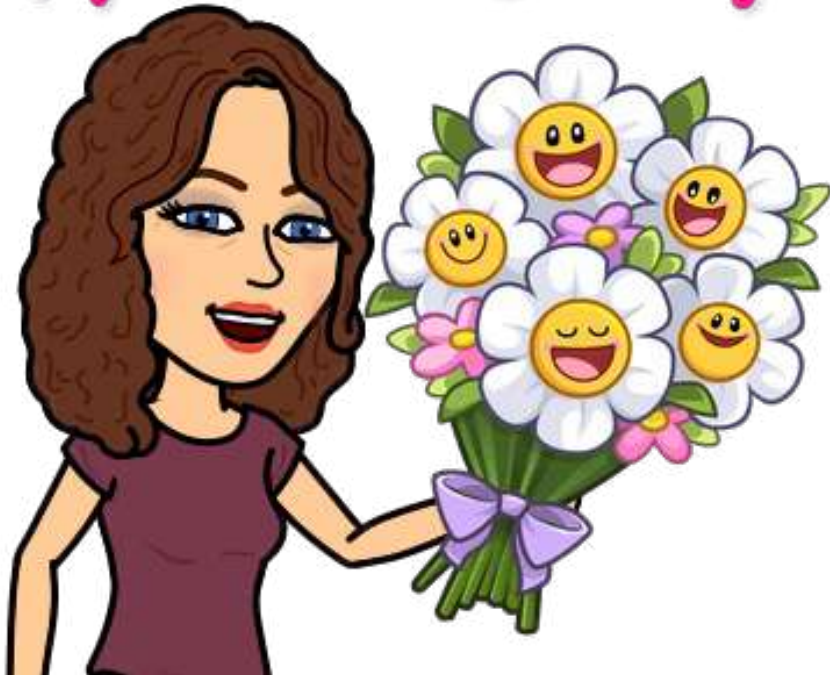
**Media
Literacy**

NAMLE

National Association for
Media Literacy Education



THANK YOU!



**CENTER FOR MEDIA
AND INFORMATION LITERACY**

www.centermil.org



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